Unit 5

Four Sharps and Four Flats

New: E major and A-flat major; C-sharp minor (B-sharp) and F minor (E-natural)

Each new key adds one sharp or one flat to the last. E major has four sharps: F, C, G and D. A-flat major has four flats: B, E, A and D. Their relative minors share the key signatures: C-sharp minor (with B-sharp as its raised 7th) and F minor (with E-natural). The keyboard pictures show which keys each scale uses: in four-sharp and four-flat keys most of the black keys are in play.

What is new

Four sharps

F-sharp, C-sharp, G-sharp, D-sharp: E major and C-sharp minor. The last sharp (D-sharp) is the 7th note of E major.

Four flats

B-flat, E-flat, A-flat, D-flat: A-flat major and F minor. The second-last flat (A-flat) names the major key.

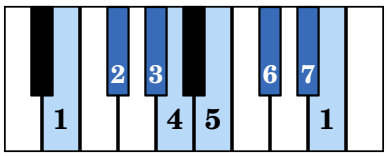
B-sharp and E-natural

The raised 7th of C-sharp minor is B-sharp (the white key C); the raised 7th of F minor is E-natural. Both appear in every V chord.

Think in shapes

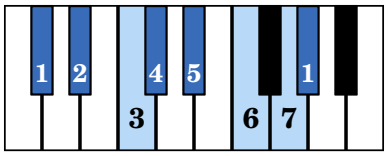
In these keys the hand sits on the black keys. Learn the I, IV and V chord shapes of each key: most passages are made of them.

E major: four sharps (F, C, G, D)



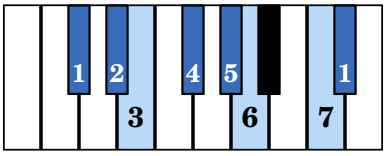
Scale degrees on the keys: E F♯ G♯ A B C♯ D♯ E

A-flat major: four flats (B, E, A, D)



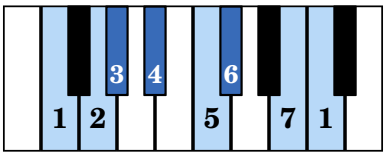
Scale degrees on the keys: A♭ B♭ C D♭ E♭ F G A♭

C-sharp minor: E major's relative minor; the raised 7th is B-sharp



Scale degrees on the keys: C♯ D♯ E F♯ G♯ A B♯ C♯

F minor: A-flat major's relative minor; the raised 7th is E-natural



Scale degrees on the keys: F G A♭ B♭ C D♭ E F

Reading tips

1. Name the key, then play the scale and the I, IV and V chords once before you read.
2. Watch for B-sharp and E-natural in the minor keys: they look strange but are the leading notes.
3. Remember the key signature in every octave and in both clefs.
4. If a passage is mostly on black keys, use your longer fingers (2, 3, 4) for them and thumbs on the white keys.

Part A: E major ♩ = 66

E major over an Alberti bass, with dynamics.

☐ **5.1**



☐ **5.2**



5.3



5.4



5.5



5.6



5.7



5.8



Part B: A-flat major ♩ = 80

A-flat major waltzes, with dynamics.

☐ **5.9**



☐ **5.10**



5.11



5.12



5.13



5.14



5.15



5.16



Part C: C-sharp minor and F minor ♩ = 66

C-sharp minor (B-sharp in the V chords) and F minor (E-natural), alternating.

☐ **5.17**



☐ **5.18**



☐ **5.19**



☐ **5.20**



☐ **5.21**



☐ **5.22**



☐ **5.23**



☐ **5.24**



Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

E Major Morning ♩ = 76

Original

Four sharps. The left hand's Alberti bass uses the shapes of E (E G-sharp B), A (A C-sharp E) and B7 (B D-sharp F-sharp A).



Moment musical No. 3 ♩ = 80

Franz Schubert (1823), Moments musicaux, D. 780 No. 3 - the opening, grace notes left out

F minor (four flats). The left hand plays an oom-pah of a bass note and a chord; E-natural, the raised 7th, is in its C major chords. A-natural in bar 7 is chromatic; in bar 8 the left hand drops from its chord to a low F. The tune is staccato; the original's grace notes are left out (they come in Unit 8). Play bars 3-10 twice. Source: Mutopia Project no. 1023 (public domain).



Impromptu in A-flat ♩= 72

Franz Schubert (1827), Impromptu, D. 935 No. 2 - the first eight bars, the last chord lengthened

Four flats. A slow sarabande: the stress is often on the second beat (the dotted quarters). The right hand plays a tune over two held notes, then three-note chords; the left hand repeats E-flat (stems up) above a slow bass (stems down). Source: Mutopia Project no. 1195 (public domain).



Moonlight Sonata ♩ = 54

Ludwig van Beethoven (1801), Sonata Op. 27 No. 2, first movement - bars 1-9, simplified

C-sharp minor, four sharps; B-sharp in bars 4 and 6 is the raised 7th. The right hand plays triplets all through (stems down) and, from bar 5, the tune above them (stems up): the tune's sixteenth comes after the third note of the triplet. The figure 3 is printed only in the first bar: all the eighths are triplets. The time signature is alla breve, but at this slow speed count four quarter beats. The left hand plays octaves. In bar 8 the right hand stretches a ninth, from the A of the triplet to the B of the tune. Beethoven asks for the pedal throughout; play without it until Unit 7, holding the bass octaves for their full length. The first triplet of bar 5, which Beethoven gives to the left hand, is in the right hand here. Notes retyped from the Mutopia Project engraving no. 276 (CC BY-SA 2.5).



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 6?

- Play two new exercises from each part at the speeds shown, with no more than one stop each.
- Pass if you name the key of each exercise before you start, and play every B-sharp and E-natural.
- Pass if you can play E Major Morning at sight, and the opening of the Moonlight Sonata after a few days.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 6.